Callum Newlands

Brand guidelines

The design rules for cnewlands.dev: colour, type, the logo, layout, components, pages, words and the things to avoid.

Callum Newlands · October 2026

Contents

How the final screens were put together, so that new pages and project write-ups look like they belong to the same site.

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Brand, colour, type and logo

What the site is for

Job

To turn warm leads from LinkedIn, Upwork and search into a message. It's the CV and the portfolio in one place.

Who reads it

Founders who need something full-stack built, and teams who want a review, an audit or a part-time tech lead (AI-first teams included). Most will skim it quickly before they decide whether to get in touch.

In one line

“Full-stack developer and part-time tech lead.” The rest of the site backs that up. [TBC: three personality words, in your words]

Principles

1. Lead with real work

Screenshots, diagrams and numbers with a source do the convincing, and the words are there to explain them. Pages that are mostly text start to feel generic.

2. Light and calm, one strong colour

Most of the page is off-white and pale green. Viridian is the one strong colour, and the dark greens are saved for product fragments and the footer.

3. A human touch in set places

A few things are tilted or stick out of their panels: the fan, the fragments, the results tiles and the photos. Grids, forms and text stay straight.

4. Specific or cut

If a block could sit on any other freelancer’s site, make it specific or take it out. Anything we don’t know yet shows as a visible [TBC] rather than a guess.

5. Accessible by default

WCAG 2.2 AA is the minimum. That means 4.5:1 for text and 3:1 for large text and controls, 44px touch targets, a visible focus state, and nothing that depends on colour or motion alone.

Colour

Everything is green. In code, name the tokens after what they do (`--colour-primary` rather than `--viridian`).

Token	Role	Contrast and limits
Viridian #067a7e	Primary: the main button, links, step numbers, logo mark	White on it 5.1:1. As text 5.0:1 on the page but only 4.35:1 on the band, so don't use it for body text on the band
Viridian dark #04585b	Hover and pressed state for viridian	8.0:1 on the page
Mid mint #a2dccf	Accent: one results tile, the review panel, the button on dark, the logo on dark. Use sparingly	Text on it #15231f (10:1+)
Pine #2f5a4a	Dark blocks: the About header band, a results tile, step numbers	White on it 7.8:1
Deep green #22332f	Footer	Mint on it 8.6:1; #9fb8b2 for small text 6.3:1
Card dark #16221f	Product fragments only (diagrams, pipeline, PR review, findings). Rows #1d2c29, code #0f1816	For "screens" only, not section backgrounds
Band #e6eeeb	Tinted sections: the headline result, the classroom band, the form section, the Contact page, Off the clock	Ink 12.5:1, subtle text 5.5:1
Page #fafcfc	Default background	Slightly off white, so white cards still stand out
Surface #ffffff	Cards, work cards, form card, option tiles	Don't use it for full-width bands, it disappears against the page

	Token	Role	Contrast and limits
	Ink #1b2b28	Text on light surfaces	Use #15231f on mint
	Muted #3a4b47	Secondary text, leads, sublines	9.0:1 on the page
	Subtle #52625e	Labels, captions, metadata (15px minimum)	6.2:1 on the page
	Line #dfe7e5	Hairlines: card borders, list and timeline rules	
	Line strong #c9d7d3	Form tile borders, the rule before More work, any divider that needs to be seen	
	Error #b3261e	Form errors only, always with an icon and a message	5.9:1 on white

Rules

- One strong block of colour per screen
- Mint is used sparingly
- No gradients, glows or coloured shadows

Status colours

These only appear inside product fragments, where they actually mean something: pass #3fae74, waiting #d9a93a, high #f3c9cf on #3a1d22.

Warm colours come from the photos

The palette has no warm colours on purpose. Screenshots, renders and photos provide them, so leave them untinted and without overlays.

Type

Bricolage Grotesque

Commissioner for reading

`Red Hat Mono for code`

Role	Font	Size (rem)	px at default size, and use
Display (h1)	Bricolage 800	`clamp(2.5rem, 1.6rem + 4vw, 5.5rem)`, lh 1, -0.02em	40 to 88px. One per page, sentence case
Section title	Bricolage 800	2.75rem; 2.5rem on phones	44px / 40px. “More work”, “Questions”, “So far”
Chapter and card title	Bricolage 800	`clamp(1.875rem, 1.4rem + 1.5vw, 2.5rem)`; 2.125rem on phones	30 to 40px / 34px. Project chapters, smaller service cards
Panel title	Bricolage 800	`clamp(2.25rem, 1.6rem + 2vw, 3.25rem)`; 2.5rem on phones	36 to 52px / 40px. The two big service panels
Callout	Bricolage 600	`clamp(1.625rem, 1.2rem + 1.4vw, 2.25rem)`; 1.375rem on phones	26 to 36px / 22px. Only for the headline result
Stat number	Bricolage 800	`clamp(2.5rem, 1.9rem + 2vw, 3.5rem)`, lh 0.95	40 to 56px. Only for numbers with a source
Lead	Commissioner 400	1.375 to 1.625rem, lh 1.45	22 to 26px. Around two lines on a phone
Body	Commissioner 400 / 500 / 600	1.125rem, lh 1.6, max-width 68ch	18px. Bold is 600 (700 is too heavy)
Small	Commissioner 400	1.0625rem, lh 1.55; 1rem, lh 1.6	17px / 16px. Card subtitles, list items, secondary text
Label and caption	Commissioner 400	0.9375rem, lh 1.5	15px. Nothing people need to read goes smaller than this
Inputs	Commissioner 400	1.0625rem	17px. Keep it at 1rem or above, otherwise phones zoom in when the field is focused

Role	Font	Size (rem)	px at default size, and use
Code	Red Hat Mono 500	0.875 to 1.0625rem	14 to 17px. Real code only. Ligatures off
Logo name	Quicksand 700	Outlined in the SVG, no font size	The name is part of the drawn logo

Use sentence case throughout. No all-caps or letter-spaced labels, no monospace labels and no headlines in two colours. Buttons and facts are set in 600. Very long single-word titles (like “swimbooker”) use the smaller title size. All the fonts are SIL OFL, so self-host them and only load the weights that are used.

Logo





- The mark is a single line where the moon (C) runs into the ridge (N)
- Viridian on light backgrounds and mint on dark, with the name in ink or white
- It’s one inline SVG with the text outlined. The mark is 48px in the nav and 38px on phones, and shouldn’t go below 32px
- Leave clear space of half the mark’s height around it
- Please don’t recolour, stretch or outline it, add effects, or set the name in a different font
- The favicon and app icon are below

Favicon and app icon



Light tab | Dark tab | 16px | 32px | 48px | 16px, enlarged | 32px, enlarged | 180px app icon | Alternative

- Just the mark, without the name
- The favicons are cropped close to the mark so it fills the square. The app icon keeps the logo's normal margin
- Each small size was redrawn on its own pixel grid with a whole-pixel stroke (2px at 16, 3px at 32 and 4px at 48). At 16px the dip is deeper and the C is shorter so the two shapes don't merge
- Viridian on a transparent background, switching to mint in dark browser themes (an SVG favicon with a `prefers-color-scheme` rule)
- The app icon is mint on deep green as a full-bleed square, and the OS rounds the corners
- Exported as an ico, PNGs, an SVG and app icons at 180, 192, 384 and 512px

Layout and components

The values below are the ones used on the final screens.

Layout, spacing and rhythm

Container

- Content is a maximum of 72.5rem (1160px), centred
- Gutters are `clamp(1rem, 4vw, 2.5rem)`
- Reading text is capped at 68ch
- Narrow pages (Contact, forms) go up to 55rem (880px)
- Phone layouts kick in below 48em (768px)

Spacing scale

0.25, 0.5, 0.75, 1, 1.5, 2, 2.5, 3.5, 4.5, 6, 7rem (4 to 112px). Sections are 6 to 7rem apart and chapters 6rem, or 8.75rem after a chapter with something overlapping its edge. Cards in a list are 4.5rem apart on phones.

Band rhythm

- Use a band when the subject changes, rather than on every section
- At most two tinted bands per page, plus the footer
- A rule before More work at the end of the page
- No white or near-white bands on the page background

Units

rem

For font sizes and the spacing around text: padding in buttons, fields and cards, gaps and section spacing. It scales with the reader's browser text size. 1rem is 16px, and the root font size isn't changed.

px

For things that should stay the same size when text gets bigger: borders and hairlines, the focus ring, shadows, corner radius and icon sizes.

Everything else

Line heights have no unit. Reading widths are in `ch`. Fluid sizes use `clamp()` with rem at both ends (`vw` on its own breaks zoom). Breakpoints are in em, and the tokens are CSS custom properties named after what they do.

Shape and depth

Radius by role

6px
Tags, nav button, small chips

8 to 10px
Screenshots and images (10px), diagram boxes (8px)

12px
Buttons, stat tiles, product fragments

14px
Big panels and cards

16px
Work cards (clickable project cards)

50%
Avatars only

Shadow by role

None
Flat cards and panels on the band

Card
Work cards only: 1px #e3ebe8 border plus this light shadow

Lift
Tilted stat tiles, the raised button

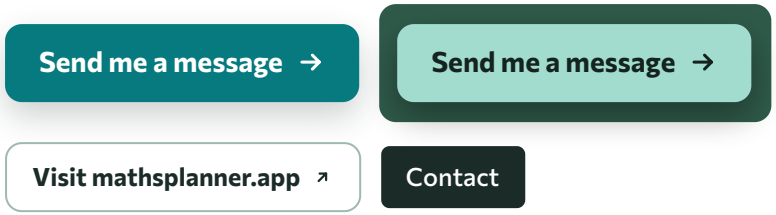
Photo
The fan in the masthead, polaroids

Float
Product fragments poking out of a panel

All shadows are neutral grey, without any colour in them.

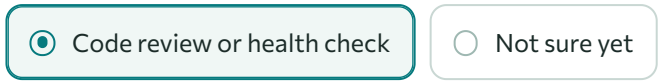
Components

Buttons and links



- **Raised primary:** one per screen. Viridian (mint on dark), 56px tall with a 12px radius and an arrow, and it lifts 2px on hover
- **Secondary:** outlined and 48px tall, with the outward arrow when the link leaves the site
- **Text links:** underlined. Icon links show the brand icon next to the name
- Button labels say what will happen, like “Send me a message” or “Send it”

The form



- The same form is used on Services and Contact, in three numbered steps: what you need, where things are at, and where to reply
- The options for what you need are tiles, so they don’t get mistaken for buttons
- Labels sit above 52px fields. Errors show when you leave a field, and there are states for sent and for sending failed
- A white card on the band, going full width with square corners on phones

Work cards

- White, with a 1px #e3ebe8 border, the card shadow, a 16px radius, 8px padding and the screenshot at 10px
- The title with an arrow, a line on what the project is, then the role and the years
- This style is only for clickable project cards
- They stack on phones (no sideways scrolling)

Product fragments

- Small, real views of the work on card dark: architecture, pipeline, PR review, board, findings and templates
- They stick out of the panel or card they belong to. On phones they always sit at the top of the card, at nearly full width
- Two can be stacked, with a screenshot overlapping a fragment
- Each one needs a text alternative (`role="img"` and a label)

Headers

- **Project:** the title, a one-line lead, three facts in a row separated by thin lines (a label and value list on phones) and a secondary button. Next to the text, a fan of three screenshots with the middle one dropped down
- **About:** the pine band with the portrait, one button and the icon links
- **Services and Contact:** just a heading and a line of text

Story pieces

- **Headline result:** a sentence or two in larger type on the band, around four lines, with no label or rule
- **Chapters:** text and a figure, switching sides each time
- **Numbered screenshot:** full width with a legend, and close-up cards on phones
- **Results:** three tiles (white, mint and pine), followed by a centred quote or links
- **Timeline:** a line with dots, with the dates on the right on phones

Treeline

Groups of tiered firs with trunks, plus a few lone trees, on rolling ground. 120px tall and purely decorative. It only goes above the footer, and on at most one band edge per page. Draw all the shapes in the same direction, otherwise the overlaps punch holes in each other.



Icons

Only where they do a job: arrow, outward arrow, calendar, email, plus the LinkedIn, GitHub and Instagram icons (from Ant Design). Always next to a text label. No icon tiles, decorative icons or ticks on lists. Lists have thin rules between the items.

Imagery

Real screenshots in white frames, and renders and photos in full colour without cropping. Personal photos go in white print frames with a slight tilt, and only on About. Placeholders say exactly what's missing, like [TBC: hiking photo].

Motion

Things only move when someone does something: the button lift, link colour changes and accordions opening. Nothing fades in on scroll, and everything respects `prefers-reduced-motion`.

Pages, phones, words and checks

Page templates

Every page has the same nav and footer. Each one has a single job and one main call to action, with the message button in the footer as a fallback on every page.

Home

The hero line and button, the fan, the work cards, the two ways to hire me, a short about section and the footer. The work section doubles as the portfolio, and “All work” links to /#work. A separate project index can wait until there are eight or so projects.

Project (template)

The header, the headline result, three or four chapters, an optional green band showing the product in use, the results with a quote or links, a rule, and two More work cards. The optional parts can be left out without leaving a gap.

Services

A heading and a line of text, four service panels (each with a fragment, a price and how the work is set up), the questions, and then the form.

About

The pine band with the portrait, two personal paragraphs and a photo, the timeline, awards with their logos, and Off the clock.

Contact

A heading and the usual reply time, the form, then a line with the other ways to reach me (email, LinkedIn, GitHub).

404 and privacy

404: a plain heading, a line of text, three links and the message button. Privacy: one column of text in short sections.

New project pages

Fill in the template and leave out the band or the quote if there isn’t one. Keep the lead to around two lines and the headline result to around four, and use wide screenshots for the fan.

Phones

Layout

- Designed at 390px, with everything in one column below 760px
- No sideways scrolling anywhere (the root hides overflow)
- The fan stays inside the screen, but screenshots and fragments can go edge to edge
- The form is full width with one option per row
- Facts become a label and value list, and the timeline dates move to the right
- Project header order: title, lead, fan, then the facts and button

Type and touch

- Section titles 2.5rem, chapter and card titles 2.125rem, body 1.125rem (40, 34 and 18px)
- The logo mark is 38px and the name stays in the nav
- Touch targets are at least 44px, and footer links are 44px tall
- For small text in screenshots, show a close-up instead of making people zoom

Words

Voice

- First person, plain and specific, as if you were explaining it to a client over a coffee
- Sentence case, no em dashes, and short sentences
- Numbers have a source and a date. Anything unknown is a visible [TBC]
- One opinion per page, in your own words

Do and don't

Do

"I look after the architecture, deployments and how we plan work."

Don't

"I deliver seamless, scalable solutions that elevate your vision."

Do

"Send me a message"

Don't

"Let's connect!" or "Submit"

Checks before shipping a page

Accessibility

- A single h1, and nav, main and footer landmarks
- Alt text says what the screenshot actually shows
- Decorative SVGs are hidden and fragments are labelled
- The keyboard order follows the visual order
- Error messages say how to fix the problem

Consistency

- Colours and sizes come from the tokens above
- One raised button per screen
- No more than two bands
- Fragments sit at the top of cards on phones
- The footer is the latest version (icons, 44px links)

The swap test

- Could this sentence appear on another developer's site? Then rewrite it
- Does every number have a source?
- Is every [TBC] on the list for the content pass?

Still open

Looking back over the project pages, and the content pass: real screenshots, quotes, numbers, prices and the reply time. There are no plans for a dark mode.

The avoid-list

Things that make a site look or read as if it was AI-generated. None of them is a giveaway on its own, but people notice when several turn up together. Check new pages and new copy against this list.

Design

Colour

- No purple or indigo, and no gradients on text, buttons or backgrounds
- No glows, aurora backgrounds or coloured shadows
- Also avoid the usual fallbacks: cream with terracotta, near-black with a single acid accent, or neon palettes with lots of accents
- A single accent colour, used sparingly

Type

- Avoid Inter, Roboto, Geist, Space Grotesk, Plus Jakarta and Instrument Serif for display text unless there's a good reason
- No two-tone headlines, single words picked out in another colour, or serif italic accents
- Sentence case, including the H1
- No all-caps, letter-spaced eyebrows (in mono or in a pill), and don't default to an eyebrow, a heading and a grey centred subline for every header

Layout and components

- No rows of identical cards with an icon on top. Give the most important thing more room
- No cards inside cards, and only one surface style per element
- No coloured borders along the top or left of cards and callouts
- No glassmorphism, bento grids for the sake of it, fake dashboards, 3D blobs or stock illustrations
- No pill-shaped nav, pill badges above the H1, status dots, or badges with live dots and middle dots
- No icon tiles in lists, and buttons don't all need an icon
- Only number things that really are a sequence

Motion

- No fading up on every section and no hover lift on every card
- Movement responds to something the user did, with at most one deliberate moment per page
- Respect prefers-reduced-motion

Imagery

- No darkened full-bleed photo with an overlay behind a huge headline
- Real screenshots, renders and photos in their own colours
- Placeholders say exactly what's missing

Copy

Patterns

- “Not just X, it’s Y”, “No X, no Y, just Z”: just say Y
- Lists of three out of habit: use however many there actually are
- Tacked-on “-ing” clauses and making things sound more important than they are: cut them
- “Serves as”, “boasts”: use “is” and “has”
- No em dashes or Title Case, and only use bold for real emphasis
- No made-up or suspiciously round numbers, and no placeholder people, companies or quotes
- No headings that could go on any site (“Why choose me”, “What I offer”)
- Don’t give every section the same shape (heading, one-line intro, three items, button)

Words

Never

elevate, unlock, unleash, empower, supercharge, revolutionise, transform (as a promise), seamless, cutting-edge, state-of-the-art, next-level, game-changer, world-class, best-in-class, delve, tapestry, testament, in today’s fast-paced / ever-evolving / digital landscape, navigate the complexities, take your X to the next level, bring your vision to life, turning ideas into reality, passionate about, look no further, whether you’re X or Y, it’s not just X it’s Y, in conclusion, X? Sorted., your dream X, starts here, find your perfect X, we’ve got you covered, premier, as seen on, FREE in capitals

Only with a concrete fact in the same sentence

leverage, robust, scalable, streamline, innovative, bespoke, tailored, solutions, end-to-end, holistic, crucial, pivotal, comprehensive, enhance, foster, showcase, underscore, meticulous, journey, ensure, valuable insights, peace of mind, results-driven, trusted partner, dedicated, high-quality

Structure

Order

- Don’t fall back on hero, logos, features, testimonials, FAQ, CTA
- Put the work first
- Plan each page around what it’s for

Calls to action

- One main call to action per page, as well as the nav button and the footer
- Not a CTA after every section
- Button labels say what will happen, and errors say what went wrong and how to fix it

Empty states

- Every layout has to look finished without testimonials, numbers or logos
- Don’t ship a placeholder figure

What we do instead

Real work on show

- Screenshots of shipped products, with captions
- The ForestGenerator renders and the preprint
- Architecture, pipeline and review fragments taken from real projects

A real person

- A real photo, written in the first person
- Actual names, years and roles
- Archery, the smallpipes and hiking, each mentioned once

Opinions

- At least one opinion per page that someone could disagree with
- Dates on things: the month you're available from, and the years on every project
- Not everything gets equal space: the main offer and the main project get the most

Deliberate exceptions

A few things on the site come close to the list but are there on purpose. Here's why.

Arrows on buttons and cards

They show that something leads somewhere. They're fine on text links too, just not on every link in a block, and an arrow should never be the only thing telling you it's a link.

Numbered steps in the form

The steps really are a sequence (what you need, your situation, where to reply), so the numbers are useful. Nothing else on the site is numbered unless it's a sequence.

Tilts and things poking out

Only the fan, the product fragments, the results tiles and the photos. Text, forms and grids stay straight.

Status colours

Only inside product fragments, where the green, amber and red show an actual state.

The FAQ

Only questions people have really asked [TBC: confirm the three]. Otherwise it comes out.

States and patterns

How the components look and behave while people use them. The focus ring is the same everywhere: a 2px viridian ring with a 2px gap, or mint on dark backgrounds.

Buttons and links

Raised button



Default | Hover | Focus | Pressed | Disabled | Sending

One per screen. On hover it lifts 2px and gets darker, and it drops back down when pressed. While a message is sending the label changes and it can't be pressed again. Only disable it when the action genuinely can't happen.

Outlined button



Default | Hover | Focus

Text links



Default | Hover | Focus

Links in body text are always underlined. "Read more" and the like are links rather than buttons, as they take you somewhere.

Nav

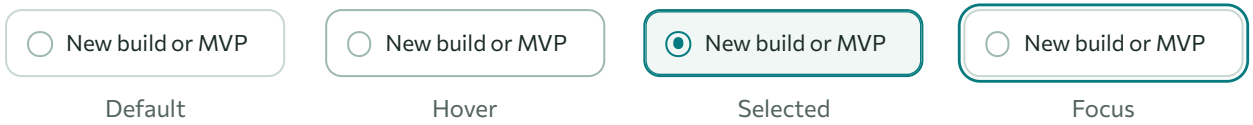


Default | Hover | Current page | Focus

The current page has a viridian underline and aria-current. The Contact button uses the button states, with a mint focus ring on the dark button.

Form

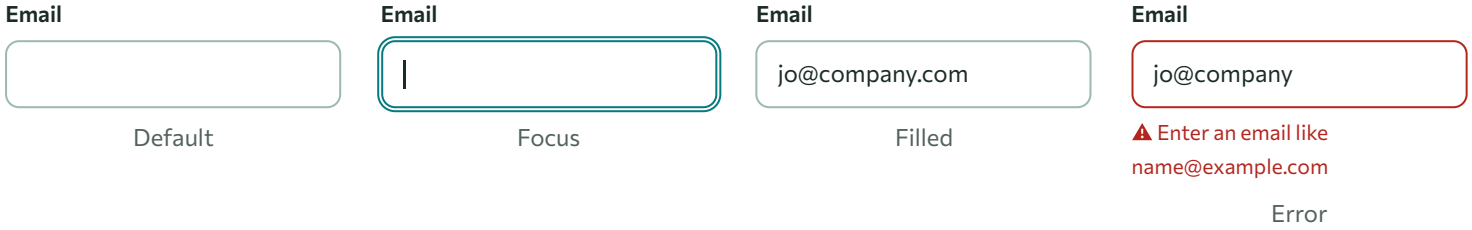
Option tiles



Default Hover Selected Focus

Each tile has a radio button inside it. The selected tile gets a thicker viridian border and a pale tint, but it shouldn't look like a filled button.

Inputs



Default Focus Filled Error

Inputs are at least 17px so phones don't zoom in. Errors are shown with colour, an icon and a message.

Your message didn't send

It's still in the form, so you can try again, or email it to callum@cnewlands.dev.

Thanks, it's on its way

I usually reply within [TBC]. A copy has gone to your inbox.

- Errors appear when you leave a field, not while you're typing
- When the form is submitted, focus goes to the first error, with a summary at the top if there's more than one
- Once it's sent, the confirmation replaces the form and gets the focus
- A hidden honeypot field catches spam, so there's no captcha

Cards

Work card

Default

Hover: border and shadow deepen



Focus

The whole card is a single link. It doesn't lift or grow on hover.

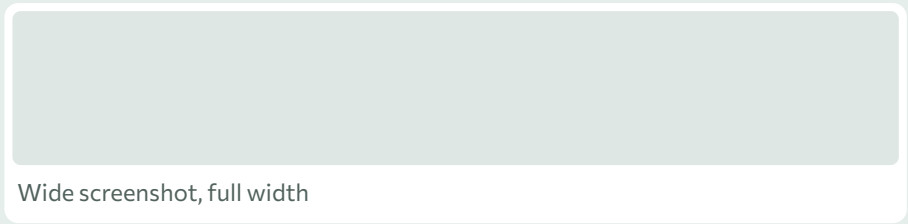
Also

- **Accordion:** only worth it when people need a few out of a lot of sections (an FAQ of six or more). If there are only a few short ones, leave them open as plain questions and answers. The whole row is the button, the plus turns into a minus, opening one doesn't close the others, nothing essential is hidden inside one, and they all expand when printed
- **Skip link:** "Skip to content", hidden until it gets focus, in the top left
- **Brand icons:** LinkedIn, GitHub and Instagram, only in ink, white or near-white

Gallery fallback

Gallery, when it's needed

- Only for screenshots that don't fit in a chapter. Most should sit next to the text they relate to
- Wide screenshots go one per row at full width, each with a caption underneath
- Phone screenshots go in rows of two or three at the same height
- Tap to see them full size. No carousels, and nothing that moves by itself
- On phones everything stacks, with phone screenshots two to a row



Wide screenshot, full width

Phone screenshots, three to a row, same height